

Camped for the night
A group of hussars gather round a campfire on the eve of the battle of Austerlitz, December 1805. The lines of fires blazing on the hill beyond give some idea of the vast size of Napoleon's army.

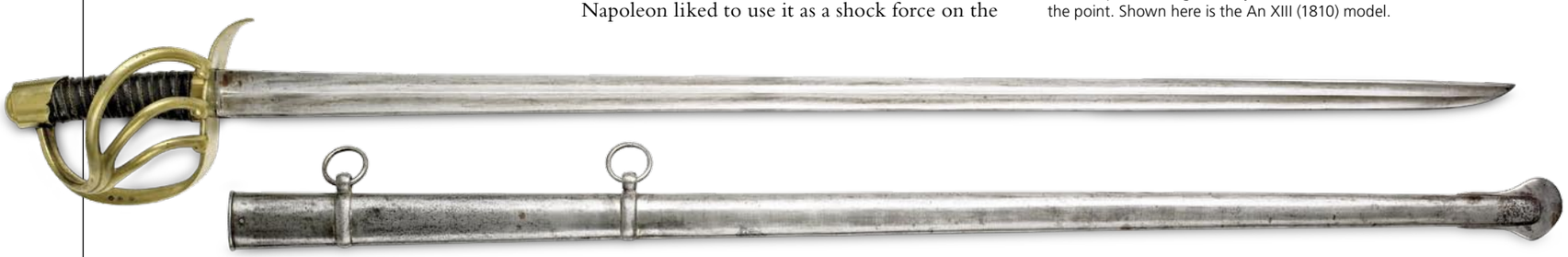
> "WHEN I SPEAK OF EXCELLENT FRENCH CAVALRY, I REFER TO ITS IMPETUOUS BRAVERY, AND NOT TO ITS PERFECTION."
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> **ANTOINE-HENRI JOMINI**, STAFF OFFICER IN NAPOLEON'S ARMY AND MILITARY THEORIST

Troopers slept two to a bed in barracks – the bed companions usually becoming close comrades in arms. Training was tough. It started with learning horsemanship by riding without saddle, bridle, or stirrups, progressing to the difficult art of using the sword or sabre and carbine while mounted. New recruits were said to habitually lose a lot of weight during initial training, so stringent were its physical demands. Grooming horses was, of course, hard unglamorous work – the French cavalry were in fact often criticized for not looking after their mounts adequately.

Like those serving in the rest of Napoleon's army, cavalry troopers had to be treated as citizen soldiers deserving of their officers' respect. There was nothing like the harsh and arbitrary discipline of the Ancien Régime army. A thoroughly professional attitude to military life was encouraged, although cavalrymen continued to assert their individuality in various ways, such as wearing their hair in long, thin pigtails. Fiery young Frenchmen keen on winning glory were temperamentally ill-adapted to the boredom of barrack life, with its interminable routines of mucking-out and drill, and were always relieved to set out on campaign. With Napoleon in charge, there was never any lack of military action.

HEAVY AND LIGHT

The most distinctive feature of Napoleonic cavalry was the prominent role given to armoured horsemen: the cuirassiers. Along with two regiments of carabiniers – also equipped with armour from 1809 – the cuirassiers constituted the heavy cavalry. Armoured horsemen had been considered an antiquated concept, looking backward to the age of the medieval knight, but Napoleon liked to use it as a shock force on the battlefield. The cuirassiers were large men mounted on large horses. They wore metal helmets and plate armour on their chest and back. For armament they carried a heavy straight sabre and a pistol. Like armoured soldiers through the ages, the cuirassiers found their metal shell hot and uncomfortable in summer; it was also very expensive. The cuirassiers were a self-conscious elite, forming the core of the cavalry reserve, which also included a number of dragoons. The reserve was only thrown into action after due deliberation, at what was considered a decisive



Heavy cavalry sabre and scabbard
The cuirassier sabre was a straight single-edged sword that could be used as a cutting weapon, but in a disciplined charge cavalrymen tended to use the point. Shown here is the An XIII (1810) model.